

Sage

Ruler

The archetype of a product whose whole promise is that you can check its work.

Brio is a decision-support layer for people who train seriously. Its founding documents refuse to overclaim in five separate places. That refusal is not caution — it is the brand.



Sage at seventy, Ruler at thirty

Brio does not sell victory. It sells a decision you are allowed to interrogate — and a structure strict enough that interrogating it is quick.

PRIMARY · 70%

Sage

Desire: to find the truth and make it usable.

Strategy: gather evidence, show the working, name the uncertainty.

Fear: being deceived — or misleading someone else.

Gift to the user: understanding, not obedience.

Brio's core screen is not a score. It is a claim with its evidence attached and its confidence stated out loud.

SECONDARY · 30%

Ruler

Desire: order where there was none.

Strategy: define the structure, bound the outputs, keep the record.

Fear: chaos — a decision no one can retrace.

Gift to the user: a system that holds.

The crucial qualification: Brio rules the data, never the athlete. Sovereignty is handed to the lifter — the recommendation is always editable and every signal can be switched off.

WHAT THE RATIO MEANS IN PRACTICE

Seventy-thirty is not a word count. It is which job a sentence is doing. Roughly seven sentences in ten should **explain, qualify or evidence**; three in ten should **structure, bound or record**. If a screen has structure but no reasoning it has drifted to Ruler and become a dashboard. If it has reasoning but no bounded action it has drifted to pure Sage and become an essay. Both failures are visible in one glance at the explain card.

THE SHADOW OF EACH, AND ITS GUARDRAIL

ARCHETYPE	SHADOW	GUARDRAIL ALREADY IN THE PRODUCT
Sage	Analysis paralysis. Lecturing. Precision used as an excuse not to decide.	Every output is one of five bounded actions. The explanation exists to serve the decision, never to replace it.
Ruler	Rigidity and control creep. Telling the athlete what they are allowed to do.	Every recommendation is editable; consent is signal-level; export and deletion are one screen away.

The documents already wrote this brand

Seven decisions taken before any brand work began. Each one is a Sage decision. None of them was made for brand reasons — which is why they are credible.

WHAT THE FOUNDING DOCUMENTS SAY	WHAT IT COMMITS THE BRAND TO
“Instead of declaring that a person is simply ‘recovered’ or ‘not recovered’ ... it recommends an explainable next action ... while showing the evidence and uncertainty behind the suggestion.”	Evidence and uncertainty travel with the claim. Always. This is the single most Sage sentence in the corpus.
“Compare a user to their own repeated measurements rather than implying a universal HRV threshold.”	Refusal of the false universal. Sage brands distrust the tidy number that flatters the seller.
“A 2022 meta-analysis found no statistically significant overall strength advantage for autoregulated versus standardised load prescription ... a coaching claim would be premature.”	The product declines the claim that would sell fastest. That is Sage's defining move, and it is already in the file.
“This is a positioning hypothesis based on product scope, not proof of willingness to pay.”	Labelling your own argument as a hypothesis, in your own pitch material.
“Do not claim performance improvement unless a study is designed and powered to test it.”	A stated evidentiary bar. Marketing is bound by it too, not just the product.
“Treat its ‘gaps’ claims as leads to verify, not facts.” — on a competitor's comparison article	Source scepticism applied to material that flatters Brio. Sage checks the evidence that agrees with it.
The explain card shows “inputs, goal, confidence and agent dissent.”	The brand publishes its own internal disagreement. Almost nothing else in the category does this.

A four-agent system that always speaks with one voice is lying about how it works. Showing the dissent is not a UI flourish; it is the archetype made visible.

Order is the product, not the packaging

The competitor Brio actually replaces is a notes file. The first thing it delivers is not intelligence — it is structure.

Four Ruler moves already committed

1. A hierarchy where there was prose. Block → split → movement → set → load × reps × RPE. Brio imposes a schema on training and then holds everything to it.

2. Five permitted outputs. Maintain, repeat, reduce, move, progress slightly. A constitution, not a conversation. The model may not invent a sixth.

3. Governance as a feature, not a legal annexe. Signal-level consent, user-visible source attribution, a recommendation audit log, export and deletion. The DPC treats this as special-category data and the AI Act as a risk tier; the brand treats both as design constraints it chose.

4. Refusal language. Escalation and non-clinical boundaries are written into the interaction, not bolted on.

Why the sovereignty runs the other way

Most Ruler brands rule the customer: the platform sets the standard and you comply. Brio inverts it. The order is imposed on the signals — the wearable exports, the nutrition CSV, the notes-app scrawl — so that the lifter can exercise judgement over something legible.

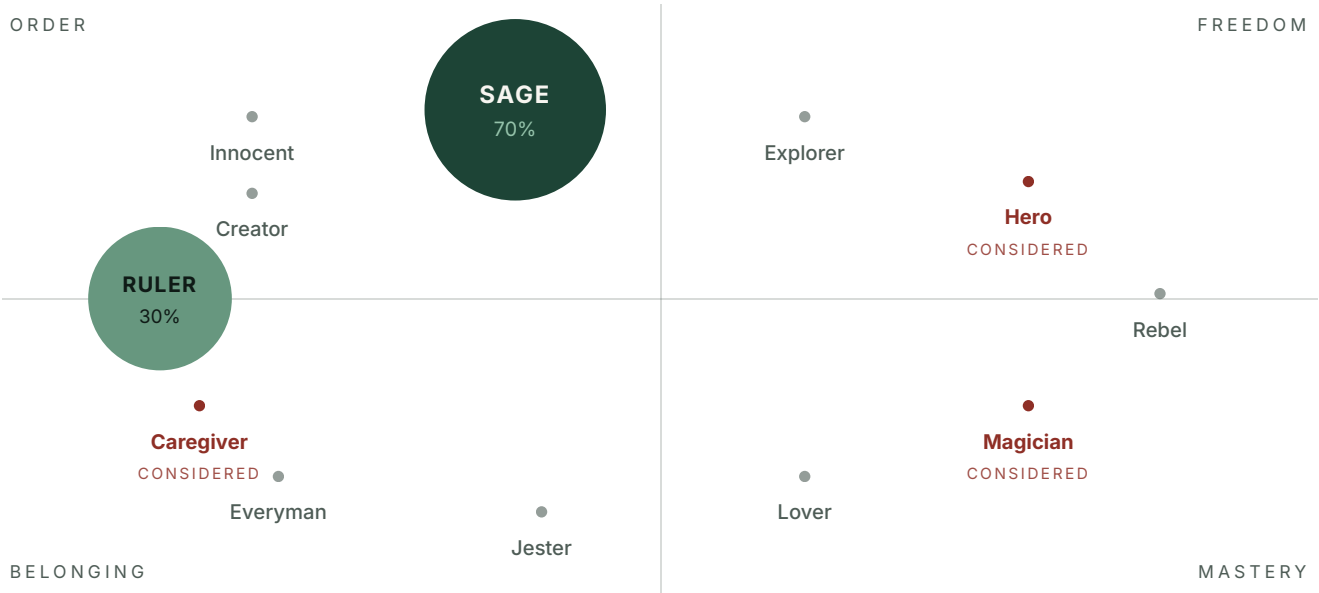
Practically, this is the line that keeps Ruler from turning into paternalism: **Brio governs its own outputs; the athlete governs the session.**

WHERE THE TENSION SITS

Sage wants to keep explaining. Ruler wants to close the question. The product resolves it the same way every time: **one bounded action first, the reasoning underneath it, and an override that costs one tap.** When the two archetypes disagree about a screen, that order is the tiebreak.

Three that fit the category and fail the product

Each of these is defensible on the surface. Each collapses against something Brio has already committed to in writing.



Both chosen archetypes sit on the **Order** side of the map — Sage reaching toward freedom of enquiry, Ruler toward the structure that makes enquiry possible. That shared axis is why a 70/30 blend holds together instead of pulling the brand in two directions. The three marked in red sit on the opposite half, which is the first clue that they were never going to fit.

REJECTED	THE CASE FOR IT	WHY IT FAILS
Hero	The category default — grit, overcoming, the PR. Every training app and every wearable brand runs on it, and gym culture rewards it.	Two independent failures. Strategically, a Hero brand inside a Hero category is invisible; there is no room left in that position. Substantively, the delivery plan's own risk register states that no performance claim is defensible. Hero writes cheques the evidence cannot cash — and the whole differentiator is not writing them.
Magician	Four agents and an orchestrator turning scattered signals into one decision. Transformation is literally the mechanism.	Magician sells the mystery and keeps the method hidden. Brio's unique selling point is the audit trail — inputs, weights, confidence, dissent. Adopting Magician would require concealing the exact thing the product exists to reveal.
Caregiver	Recovery, deloads, escalation language, non-clinical safeguards — and a sage green palette that already leans restorative.	The closest miss. Caregiver's failure mode is paternalism: deciding for someone, protecting them from information. That collides head-on with the editable recommendation and stated athlete agency. The care in Brio shows up as governance and consent, which is Ruler exercised with restraint — not Caregiver.

Creator, Explorer and Everyman are present in the tone — the lifter builds their own block, Brio is unpretentious about jargon — but none of them is load-bearing enough to earn a share of the identity.

Four principles

Voice is constant. Tone moves. These four do not change between the pitch deck, the empty state and the error message.

1 • Show the working

Every claim arrives with its evidence and its uncertainty in the same breath. Brio does not finish the sentence “repeat last week's top set” without saying why, from what, and how sure. If a statement cannot carry its evidence, it does not ship.

2 • Bound the claim

Say what the data supports and name the limit out loud. “Your 7-day resting heart rate is above your own baseline” — not “you are not recovered.” The first is measurable and falsifiable. The second is a diagnosis Brio is not permitted to make.

3 • The lifter decides

Brio recommends; it never instructs, congratulates or scolds. No streaks, no guilt, no “you crushed it.” When a recommendation is overridden, Brio records the override and says nothing about it. Confirmation dialogues that argue with the user are prohibited.

4 • Plain over clinical, precise over casual

A physiologist should not wince; a lifter should not need a glossary. When a technical term is the only accurate word — RPE, RIR, HRV — use it and define it once, in place. Never soften a number into a vibe, and never inflate a vibe into a number.

THE TEST, IF YOU ONLY REMEMBER ONE THING

Could a sceptical strength coach read this sentence and check it?
If not, rewrite it until they can.

Register by moment

The same voice, at six different temperatures. The column on the right is the failure the moment invites.

MOMENT	BLEND	REGISTER	NEVER
Onboarding & consent	Ruler-led	Slow, complete, literal. Name every signal read and how to switch it off, before asking for anything.	Bundled permissions. “We take your privacy seriously.”
The daily recommendation	Balanced	The shortest register Brio has. One action, one because, one confidence. Under twenty-five words.	Motivation. Exclamation marks. A number without a referent.
The explain card	Sage-led	The fullest register. Inputs, goal, weighting, confidence, and which agent disagreed and why.	Hiding the dissent to look decisive.
Missing or stale data	Sage-led	State the gap, state what is still usable, lower the confidence and say so.	“Oops!” Apology theatre. Pretending the gap is not there.
Escalation	Ruler-led	Flat, brief, non-clinical. Name the boundary and hand over cleanly.	Alarm. Diagnosis. Reassurance Brio cannot support.
Pitch & marketing	Sage-led	Concrete, comparative, unembarrassed about limits. Lead with what the competitors genuinely do well.	Superlatives. “AI-powered.” Any performance claim.

VOICE UNDER PRESSURE

When Brio is uncertain — say the confidence and say what would raise it. Vague hedging (“might”, “could possibly”) is worse than a stated low confidence.

When the agents disagree — publish it. A unanimous answer from a four-agent system is a claim about the system, and if it is not true, it is a lie.

When the lifter overrides — record, do not argue. No “are you sure?”. The override is data, not disobedience.

When there is nothing to say — say nothing. A Sage brand is allowed a quiet day. Manufactured daily insight is the fastest way to lose the trust the rest of this document is trying to build.

Say this, not that

Most of the brand is decided at word level. These are not style preferences; each pairing encodes one of the four principles.

SAY	NOT	BECAUSE
signals	your body's data	Names what is actually read, and keeps it plural and partial.
recommendation	prescription plan orders	Non-clinical, and leaves the decision where it belongs.
confidence: moderate	we're pretty sure	Uncertainty is a value in the system, not a tone of voice.
above your own 7-day baseline	abnormal not recovered	Within-person comparison. No universal threshold, no diagnosis.
reduce top-set RPE	take it easy today	Bounded and executable. "Easy" is unmeasurable.
Brio reads ...	Brio knows ...	Reading is what it does. Knowing is a claim it has not earned.
you can override this	you should ...	Agency, stated rather than implied.
not yet tested	proven clinically validated	The evidentiary bar is a brand asset. Do not spend it.

WORDS BRIO DOES NOT USE

crush · beast mode · grind · unlock · transform · journey · effortless · revolutionary · game-changing · AI-powered · seamlessly · optimise (used bare) · personalised (unqualified) · smart · 62% recovered

The last one is not a word but a habit: a bare score with no referent and no evidence. It is the exact thing Brio was built to replace.

The same message, twice

Left column is what the category writes. Right column is Brio.

The daily card

CATEGORY DEFAULT · HERO

You're 62% recovered — time to attack it. Let's go get that PR!

BRIO · SAGE 70 / RULER 30

Repeat last week's top set — 100 kg × 5. Your 7-day resting heart rate is 4 bpm above your own baseline, sleep is down 52 minutes across three nights, and Monday's session finished at RPE 9. **Confidence: moderate.** The progression agent wanted a small increase; the readiness agent did not. You can override this.

Missing data

CATEGORY DEFAULT

Oops! Something went wrong. Please try again later.

BRIO

No sleep data since Tuesday. This recommendation is running on training load and nutrition only.

Confidence: low. Reconnect WHOOP, or log the session and decide for yourself — Brio will record which you chose.

The pitch line

CATEGORY DEFAULT

Brio is an AI-powered personalised fitness platform that revolutionises how athletes train.

BRIO — ALREADY WRITTEN, IN THE POSITIONING FILE

Hevy knows what you lifted. WHOOP knows how you slept. Neither tells you what to do in the next hour, and no one tells you why. Brio is where those two facts meet — in a decision you can interrogate.

The third example is not a rewrite. It is a line already in the positioning document, which is evidence that the team is writing in this voice before anyone named it.

How Sage and Ruler produced the colour and the mark

The palette and the logo are not decoration applied afterwards. Each decision below traces to a line on page one.

Brio

NAME

brí — Irish: strength, vigour; force, significance, from Proto-Celtic *brīgos. One word that means both **energy** and **meaning** — which is precisely the join the product makes. The Italian con brio — with spirit — is the second reading, and the two do not contradict. The name authenticates the Celtic mark rather than decorating with it.

COLOUR



Bone #F7F5F0

Mist #DBE6DF

Sage #67977F

Brioch #1D4436

Ink #0F1A16

Slate #4E5C56

Bronze #8A5A18

Sage green is the positioning statement. The category is black, charcoal and neon — the colour language of exertion. Brio's ground is the colour of considered judgement. In a room of shouting brands, restraint is the loudest available move, and it is the only one consistent with refusing to overclaim. **Bronze, not gold**, is the accent: Celtic metalwork rather than trophy. It marks confidence and emphasis and appears once per view — Ruler's discipline about scarce attention.

Every text pairing in the system is measured against WCAG 2.2 AA and passes. For a brand whose entire claim is legibility of reasoning, an unreadable label would be a contradiction, not a bug. Two rules follow directly from the archetype: colour never carries a state on its own — under deuteranopia Bronze, Rust and Slate converge, so every recommendation ships with its word; and Sage is a field, never a sentence.

MARK

A triquetra: three interlaced vesicas inside a ring, drawn only from circular arcs. **The three petals are the three signals Brio joins** — training, recovery, nutrition. **The ring is the loop** — connect, log, compare, decide, learn. They are woven, not stacked, because the product's claim is that the three are inseparable; a stack would say one sits on top of the others.

Two Sage properties matter here. The mark is **constructible**: six circles and a rule, no hand-drawn curve, so anyone can redraw it and check it. And it is **self-explanatory once told** — the geometry carries the thesis rather than illustrating it. The Ruler contribution is the discipline around it: one clear-space rule, one minimum size, one compact variant below 32 px, and no rotation or recolouring.

Continuity with the existing design is deliberate. The sage green is sampled from the original artwork and the triquetra-as-o construction is retained; what changed is that the mark now sits at x-height so the word is read before the symbol, the strand weight matches the letterform stems, and the tittle is a plain dot so the logo has one knot rather than two.

The card to keep open

Brio is

A Sage brand with a Ruler spine. It exists to make one training decision legible, and to hold itself to a structure that lets you check it.

Voice

- Show the working — evidence and uncertainty in the same breath.
- Bound the claim — say only what the data supports.
- The lifter decides — recommend, never instruct.
- Plain over clinical, precise over casual.

Before anything ships

- Does the claim carry its evidence?
- Is the confidence stated, not implied?
- Is the action one of the five?
- Could the lifter override it in one tap?
- Would a sceptical strength coach be able to check it?
- Does any colour carry meaning without a word beside it?

The one-line test

If it would embarrass us in front of someone who read the meta-analysis, it is off-brand.

Sources for the archetype case: Elevator_Pitch, Idea_Validation, Unique_Selling_Point, Value_Proposition, Recommendations and Methodology_and_Ranked_List (project files, 20 August 2026); positioning.md and delivery-plan.md (project docs, 1 September 2026). Etymology of brí: Ó Dónaill, Foclóir Gaeilge–Béarla, via teanglann.ie; Proto-Celtic *brīgos via Omniglot Celtiadur. Contrast ratios computed to the WCAG 2.2 relative-luminance formula.